evening and coupled with the impact of the Supreme Court's order of the previous day, Indira Gandhi may have asked Gen. Raina to keep the army ready to aid the civil administration, should there be any need for the same.

Addressing that rally at Ram Lila Maidan in Delhi, JP called for a nationwide satyagraha demanding Prime Minister Gandhi's resignation. He also exhorted the army, police and civil service personnel not to obey the 'illegal and immoral orders' of the government.

Almost coinciding with the end of JP's rally that evening, members of the Political Affairs Committee (PAC) – Indira Gandhi and her three senior cabinet colleagues, Babu Jagjivan Ram, Sardar Swaran Singh and Y.B. Chavan – met to discuss the implications of the Supreme Court order. After due deliberation, it was decided that the following morning (26 June), she would resign and Sardar Swaran Singh would take over as interim prime minister. As it was believed that Sinha's judgment was based on flimsy grounds, it was expected that his order would be reversed by the Supreme Court in three months' time, when Indira Gandhi could return as PM with her position legally vindicated.

Sanjay Gandhi, who came to know about the PAC decision, immediately consulted Bansi Lal, the chief minister of Haryana, who told him that his mother was mistaken if she thought Swaran Singh would hand over the PM's post to her even after the Supreme Court decided the case in her favour. The other senior Congress leaders could gang up against her to prevent her from returning to power. Consequently, Sanjay consulted Siddhartha Shankar Ray, on whose advice a letter was written by the prime minister to the president, requesting him to sign the proclamation of National Emergency on the grounds of imminent threat to the security of India from internal disturbances. A compliant President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmad signed the proclamation minutes before the midnight of 25 June, leading to the imposition of Emergency with effect from 26 June. The rest is history.

Though Sanjay Gandhi had been influencing his mother following her victory at the March 1971 national elections, it was the declaration of National Emergency at his behest that marked the